

Chapter 70 - Part 1

After Su Meiqi finished saying this, only Zhou Yi'an let out a light snort in the office.

It wasn't mockery, just pure annoyance at Su Meiqi.

Su Meiqi bared her fangs and brandished her claws¹, wanting to punch someone, but Zhou Yi'an poked her with a pen, aiming at her hand. "Don't touch me. Do you still want to interview or not?"

"It's definitely ruined." Su Meiqi gritted her teeth. "You've already exposed my identity, how am I supposed to get into this company?!"

"But I still got in." Zhou Yi'an said.

Su Meiqi: "....."

In less than two seconds, she sat properly in the chair across from the interviewer, incredibly well-behaved.

Meanwhile, Xu Qingzhu looked at Su Meiqi very seriously. According to the resume, she was a year younger than her, had gone abroad to study design at the graduate level, and had been back in the country for a year.

She could remember these details after reading them just once.

Right now, she was mainly looking at Su Meiqi's face—delicate features, fair skin, with the sense of a beautiful girl who had walked out of an anime.

Mainly, there was a spirited energy about her.

Before she could say anything, Su Meiqi spoke to Zhou Yi'an again: "Sister Zhou, your teacher isn't called Su Yao anymore."

"I know." Zhou Yi'an looked down at the portfolio, twirling the pen between her slender fingers. "But the name Su Yao is still remembered by people."

"What use is that?" Su Meiqi scoffed lightly. "Can reporting her name get me exempted from the interview? She hasn't emerged from retirement in how many years."

Zhou Yi'an: "Anyway, it's more useful than reporting your own name."

Su Meiqi: "....."

A few seconds later, Su Meiqi said through gritted teeth: "Just wait, I'll definitely beat you once in the future!"

"Wait until your next life then." Zhou Yi'an's tone was quite irritating. "When have you ever beaten me since childhood?"

Su Meiqi: ".....How infuriating."

Zhou Yi'an glanced at her. "Are you here for an interview? How can you talk to the interviewer like this?"

"You're not the main interviewer." Su Meiqi said: "Can you stop using a tiger's skin² to bully people? Using a chicken feather as an arrow of authority³, looking like a petty person who's achieved success."

Zhou Yi'an: "....."

"You can leave now." Zhou Yi'an said: "There's no way you'll pass the interview."

"Hey!" Su Meiqi was so angry she immediately became irritable.

But before she could argue with her again, Xu Qingzhu, who had been quiet the whole time, said: "Keep her."

Her cool voice carried decisive efficiency without any hesitation, and she maintained absolute rationality when speaking. "I really like your work and design philosophy."

Su Meiqi was stunned, still in a dazed state.

Instead, Zhou Yi'an casually looked at Xu Qingzhu and said coldly: "You'd better think clearly—she's the heiress of Haiwei Jewelry."

"I even dared to hire you." Xu Qingzhu looked at her, radiating confidence from within, and smiled. "So what if she's the heiress of a rival company? Looking at it positively, I've captured a hostage."

Su Meiqi's face immediately fell. "Sister Xu, I'm really here to find work. I don't want to go back to my family's company—I'd be tortured to death by my dad... I definitely won't leak company secrets. If you still don't think it's acceptable, I can sign an additional confidentiality agreement."

"No need to sign a confidentiality agreement." Xu Qingzhu said: "It will be in your employment contract, the same as all other employees. You won't be treated differently. Of course, if you go around announcing that you're the heiress of Haiwei Jewelry, then that's beyond my consideration."

"Ah, definitely not." Su Meiqi immediately explained: "It's only because Sister Zhou is here that I was exposed, otherwise I could keep my mouth shut until I resign."

Who would want the company's people to know they're the heiress of a rival company for no reason?!

And also.....

Su Meiqi showed her bracelet. "Look, even the products I use are from your company."

"What a coincidence." Xu Qingzhu smiled. "This design was created by your Sister Zhou."

Su Meiqi: "....."

"We're really enemies." Su Meiqi sighed.

Zhou Yi'an: "Please don't, let's pretend we don't know each other."

Xu Qingzhu looked at the two of them, then said: "You can go home and wait for news first. HR will send you an email."

Su Meiqi nodded frantically, but before leaving the office, she said to Zhou Yi'an: "Sister Zhou, are you coming to my house for dinner tonight? My aunt is sick again."

Zhou Yi'an pursed her lips: "Doesn't she get sick at this time every year?"

Su Meiqi: "....."

She was angry. "Can you accumulate some verbal virtue⁴ for yourself? This year it's just a simple cold."

Zhou Yi'an lazily said, "Got it, I'll go."

After she left, only Xu Qingzhu and Zhou Yi'an remained in the office.

Zhou Yi'an had already prepared herself to be questioned, but Xu Qingzhu flipped through the resumes in her hands and directly called the next person's name.

Zhou Yi'an: "....."

She really could keep her composure.

Footnotes:

¹ **Bared her fangs and brandished her claws (張牙舞爪)** - A Chinese idiom describing someone acting in an aggressive, threatening, or overbearing manner.

² **Using a tiger's skin (扯着虎皮)** - Part of a Chinese idiom meaning to use borrowed authority or power to intimidate others; pretending to have more power than one actually does.

³ **Using a chicken feather as an arrow of authority (拿着雞毛當令箭)** - A Chinese idiom meaning to treat something trivial as if it were very important; using a small amount of authority to lord it over others.

⁴ **Accumulate some verbal virtue (積點口德)** - A Chinese expression meaning to watch one's words and speak more kindly; to build up good karma through one's speech rather than saying harsh or mean things.

Chapter 70 - Part 2

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After interviewing everyone, Xu Qingzhu mentioned the few people she was interested in, then asked Zhou Yi'an for her opinion.

Zhou Yi'an disagreed with her and raised an opposing view about one person whose educational background wasn't very high but whose design work was very innovative.

"Her work carries a heavy imitative style." Zhou Yi'an said: "Given time, plagiarism will probably be exposed."

Xu Qingzhu asked: "Who did she imitate?"

"Don't you think this work is very similar to Su Yao's award-winning piece in Berlin back then? She just changed the color scheme and the shape on the right side." Zhou Yi'an said: "We can't have this kind of opportunistic person. It looks innovative, but actually she's just picking up others' discarded wisdom¹. Sooner or later, problems will explode."

Xu Qingzhu stared at that work, looking at it again and again, but only smiled silently.

Among all the design works, this was her favorite piece.

It seemed there was some kind of inexplicable fate at work.

However, she didn't dwell on it, letting coldness suppress those complex emotions and complicated feelings.

In the end, she chose to listen to Zhou Yi'an's opinion and kept the few people Zhou Yi'an favored.

After handing the list to HR, Xu Qingzhu sat there organizing her things.

Zhou Yi'an suddenly said: "You quite surprise me."

"What?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

"I thought you would choose that person." Zhou Yi'an said: "I've never been one to listen to opinions from people I dislike."

"That's you." Xu Qingzhu said: "As for me, I'll listen to opinions from everyone who seriously gives me advice, especially since I actively asked you."

After she finished speaking, she paused, then looked at Zhou Yi'an. "I don't dislike you, although I know you had a part in the Huayue International matter."

Zhou Yi'an's expression changed slightly, then she laughed lightly. "Then you can really endure things."

"It's not about enduring." Xu Qingzhu said: "I've also set you up once, so we're even."

Only then did Zhou Yi'an remember that at the Liang family banquet before, Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu had worked together to set her up.

Liang Shi was quite crazy back then.

But... she lacked the energy that she liked.

Actually, if you asked Zhou Yi'an to explain what kind of energy it was, she couldn't really say.

But it just felt different.

"Clear about love and hate²." Zhou Yi'an's voice was lazy, carrying a casual, devil-may-care attitude. "If it were me, I would keep seeking revenge."

"Revenge won't make my life better, and I have more important things to do than seeking revenge." Xu Qingzhu said: "If you're trying to introduce yourself to me, I don't think it's necessary. I only need to know your work capabilities. I have a meeting in a bit, I need to go. What about you?"

"Aren't you going to ask me something?" Zhou Yi'an glanced at the door. "Like about Su Meiqi."

"There's nothing to ask." Xu Qingzhu said: "I'm the one who wants to keep her, so I'll bear the consequences. Mainly because I feel..."

She paused, then smiled. "She and I are quite fated, after all, her aunt was the person who almost became my aunt-in-law³. What do you think?"

Zhou Yi'an paused slightly.

They were both smart people—what wasn't there to understand?

Zhou Yi'an smiled, put the pen in her pocket, and shrugged indifferently. "Indeed quite fated."

After that, she remained silent.

Xu Qingzhu remained the same as usual during the subsequent meeting, as if what just happened had no effect on her at all.

Instead, Zhou Yi'an's mind wandered once during the meeting.

Su Meiqi had sent her many messages.

【Sister An'an, want some bubble tea?】

【I'll order you bubble tea, can you please not speak badly of me in front of Sister Xu?】

【Sister An'an, QAQ pitiful.jpg】

【.....】

Zhou Yi'an slacked off during the meeting and replied to her: 【Do you know something?】

Su Meiqi: 【Stunned.jpg, what would I know?】

Zhou Yi'an: 【How do you know Xu Qingzhu?】

Su Meiqi: 【Last time I helped her catch a robber, and we even went up Yunfeng Mountain together.】

Zhou Yi'an: 【Then why did you bring up Teacher Su today?】

Su Meiqi: 【.....I simply wanted to remind you not to betray your teacher and destroy your ancestors⁴.】

Zhou Yi'an: 【.....】

Su Meiqi: 【Mainly I wanted to tell you not to bully your teacher's niece, wuwuwu. It's not easy for a kid to find a reliable job. I've already declared I want to live independently, and my little cubs⁵ in the game are about to starve to death because I can't support them anymore.】

Zhou Yi'an could guess she was talking about those little characters in her game.

Looking at her screen full of "wuwuwu," Zhou Yi'an transferred twenty thousand yuan to her.

Su Meiqi: 【!】

Su Meiqi: 【A goddess fairy! Are there really such beautiful and kind-hearted fairies in this world?】

Su Meiqi: 【When you come to dinner tonight, I'll have Sheng Yu dance for you!】

Zhou Yi'an: 【.....】

Su Meiqi, who sold out her little cousin without any guilt, accepted Zhou Yi'an's transfer and sent five or six emoticons of kneeling in gratitude.

Meanwhile, Zhou Yi'an stared at the screen, deep in thought.

Su Meiqi still doesn't know?

But that also seemed normal.

Su Zhe, Su Meiqi's father, had never publicly disclosed Su Yao's whereabouts over the years. Previously, Su Yao had always been abroad, only occasionally being brought back to the country to stay for a while when her condition was stable.

It was only in recent years that she was truly brought back to the country.

And Su Yao's mental state hadn't completely stabilized either. It only improved somewhat after giving birth to Sheng Yu.

She had even been called Sheng Yu abroad the whole time. After returning to the country, just to be safe, they gave Sheng Yu a new name—Su Yu.

This was the name used at kindergarten.

Su Yao seemed to have disappeared from people's sight for a long time.

But actually, her works kept appearing. Her spiritual talent in design was truly incomparable to anyone.

If not for her designs, Haiwei Jewelry couldn't possibly have grown to become an industry leader in twenty years.

Footnotes:

¹ **Picking up others' discarded wisdom (拾人牙慧)** - A Chinese idiom meaning to repeat or imitate what others have said or done; lacking originality and just copying others' ideas.

² **Clear about love and hate (愛憎分明)** - A Chinese expression describing someone who has clear-cut attitudes about what and whom they like or dislike; having strong principles and not being ambiguous about their feelings.

³ **Aunt-in-law (舅媽)** - The wife of one's maternal uncle; in this context, Su Yao almost married Xu Qingzhu's maternal uncle, which would have made her Xu Qingzhu's aunt-in-law.

⁴ **Betray your teacher and destroy your ancestors (欺師滅祖)** - A Chinese idiom meaning to be disrespectful or disloyal to one's teacher and ancestors; showing ingratitude to those who taught you.

⁵ **Little cubs (小崽崽們)** - An affectionate term in Chinese internet slang, often used to refer to virtual pets, game characters, or anything small and cute that one takes care of.

Chapter 70 - Part 3

Zhou Yi'an met Su Yao when she was studying abroad. Back then, she was sent out of the country for high school and was quite lost.

She met Su Yao while wandering the streets. Su Yao could only see with one eye and often wore sunglasses. She would wander around on roads covered with fallen leaves, sit on benches in a daze, and sit there for an entire afternoon.

Later, Zhou Yi'an sat there and drew her portrait.

After seeing it, Su Yao said: "Let me teach you to draw other things."

At the time, she thought this woman was crazy.

Although she later discovered that this woman indeed had a condition.

But during those boring and confused days, it was Su Yao who taught her many things, and she ended up majoring in design in college.

Without Su Yao, there wouldn't be the Zhou Yi'an of today.

Zhou Yi'an had thought she was just an ordinary crazy person. After all, people who do art are all somewhat abnormal to varying degrees.

But later she discovered that things weren't as simple as she thought.

There were many versions of Su Yao's story available with just a search online.

Her love story with the genius architectural designer Sheng Qinglin was hyped up everywhere.

It wasn't until she met Su Zhe that she mentioned the name Sheng Qinglin.

Su Zhe said with disgust: "Inauspicious¹."

He repeatedly warned her not to mention this name in front of Su Yao.

But later, when Su Yao became slightly more lucid, she changed her name to Su Mu.

She said Su Yao was dead, and the one who survived was Su Mu.

"Mu" was formed by taking half of each character from "Qinglin²."

She would live the rest of her life carrying Sheng Qinglin with her.

Zhou Yi'an had once been curious about Su Yao's story, but out of respect, she suppressed this curiosity.

It was later, when she investigated Xu Qingzhu on a whim, that she saw a familiar name—Sheng Qinglin.

With just a little attention to piecing together the rumors in certain circles, one would know that back then, the famous Sheng Linlang of Haizhou had become pregnant before marriage. Some said she was indiscreet, others said the child wasn't hers.

Then Zhou Yi'an obtained a strand of Xu Qingzhu's hair and had it tested against Su Yao's DNA.

She always preferred straightforward methods of verification.

Then she also tested Xu Qingzhu's DNA against Sheng Yu's.

Xu Qingzhu was the daughter of Su Yao and Sheng Qinglin.

Sheng Yu was Xu Qingzhu's biological younger sister.

And Sheng Yu, as the child Su Yao desperately gave birth to while commemorating Sheng Qinglin, actually existed in another form.

But Su Yao didn't remember.

She had once been diagnosed with mental instability. After being stimulated, she lost her memories and didn't even recognize her own brother, only remembering Sheng Qinglin.

It took many years before she recovered to her current state.

Xu Qingzhu must have heard those rumors too. Moreover, when she said that sentence in the interview room just now, what she meant was—fated but not meant to be together³, I don't want to know about Su Yao's relationship with me.

She must have guessed something.

She guessed it, but suppressed her curiosity and didn't verify it.

She was a person who was calm and rational to the point of being almost cold.

Zhou Yi'an had thought Su Meiqi knew something and that's why she came to this company, but it seemed she was overthinking.

Moreover, Zhou Yi'an had just prepared herself to mock Xu Qingzhu.

About not caring about her biological mother, things like that.

But she didn't want to hear anything.

Zhou Yi'an didn't say it either.

There are boundaries in interactions between adults.

Perhaps she had previously thought about hurting her, but after knowing she was her teacher's daughter...

Zhou Yi'an only had ten thousand curse words she wanted to say.

If only she had investigated earlier.

After the meeting ended, around noon, Xu Qingzhu directly said: "Designer Zhou, please stay behind."

Zhou Yi'an placed her phone screen-down on the table. "What is it?"

"I saw you had something to say to me." Xu Qingzhu said: "Let's have lunch together."

Zhou Yi'an: "....."

She had nothing to say.

Footnotes:

¹ **Inauspicious (晦氣)** - A Chinese term meaning unlucky, ill-omened, or bringing bad luck; expressing strong disgust or the feeling that something/someone brings misfortune.

² **"Mu" formed by taking half of each character from "Qinglin" (「清林」各取一半是為沐)** - In Chinese characters, "清" (Qing) contains the water radical "氵" and "林" (Lin) contains the wood/tree component "木". Taking the water radical from "清" (氵) and the wood component from "林" (木) creates the character "沐" (Mu), which means "to wash" or "to bathe," symbolically representing that Su Yao is washing/bathing herself in the memory of Sheng Qinglin for the rest of her life.

³ **Fated but not meant to be together (有緣無分)** - A Chinese idiom describing a relationship where two people are destined to meet (have fate/yuan) but are not meant to be together or have a deep relationship (lack the portion/share/fen that would bind them together).

Chapter 70 - Part 4

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Xu Qingzhu and Zhou Yi'an having lunch together was actually quite a novelty.

Mainly because in this company, anyone having lunch with Zhou Yi'an was a novelty.

As everyone knew, Zhou Yi'an drove a car worth over two million to work, wore accessories that were all six figures, and her clothes cost tens of thousands.

If her personality were better, perhaps some people would want to be friends with her.

But this one was a total aloof queen¹. She never talked to people. After coming to the company, she would just sit at her workstation, draw some designs, play on her phone, and leave when it was time to clock out—never socializing with anyone.

People gave her the nickname "Loner Weirdo."

Even Lumi, known as the office's social butterfly extraordinaire², was defeated, saying this was a hard bone she couldn't gnaw through, an iceberg she couldn't melt.

Yet Xu Qingzhu went out to lunch with her at noon, at a Hunan cuisine restaurant³.

Zhou Yi'an looked at her leisurely. "What do you want to ask me?"

"Nothing." Xu Qingzhu said: "Just simply treating you to a meal to thank you for your advice this morning."

Zhou Yi'an: "....."

She had thought Xu Qingzhu couldn't resist her curiosity and was going to ask.

This feeling of having words at the tip of her tongue but being unable to say them was also quite uncomfortable.

But Zhou Yi'an didn't ask anything extra either, just ate quietly.

After they finished eating, Xu Qingzhu finally said: "You stared at me for half an hour during the meeting. What did you want to say to me?"

"Would you listen to whatever I say?" Zhou Yi'an asked back.

Xu Qingzhu pressed her lips together: "Su Yao....."

This name took quite a lot of effort and courage to say from her mouth.

But she paused, then still asked: "Has she been doing well these years?"

"May I ask in what capacity are you asking?" Zhou Yi'an curved her lips, smiling quite wickedly. She pulled out a cigarette from her pocket, but after seeing Xu Qingzhu's somewhat pale face, she held the cigarette between her fingers and spun it a few times without lighting it.

However, Xu Qingzhu shrugged. "Just asking casually. If you don't want to say it, forget it. I thought you would really want to say something."

Zhou Yi'an: "....."

"Advancing by retreating⁴?" Zhou Yi'an asked.

Xu Qingzhu shook her head: "Sincere."

After saying this, she settled the bill, got up to leave. Zhou Yi'an, with her back to her, let out a light breath.

Xu Qingzhu had already walked out of the restaurant. The sky after rain was indeed much fresher.

Moreover, at this time of year, temperatures fluctuated dramatically. Yesterday it was cold at four or five degrees, but today it rose back up to over ten degrees.

The sun shone warmly on people. Xu Qingzhu's back was cool and desolate, yet extraordinarily charismatic.

Zhou Yi'an sat upstairs watching for a while. After her figure disappeared, guessing she had returned to the company, she sent her a message: 【Someone who's been living in a psychiatric hospital for years—do you think she's doing well?】

Footnotes:

¹ **Aloof queen (拽姐)** - Chinese internet slang describing a woman who is arrogant, cool, and unapproachable; someone who acts superior and doesn't associate with others easily.

² **Social butterfly extraordinaire / Social bull ceiling (社牛天花板)** - Chinese internet slang where "社牛" (social bull/cow) refers to someone extremely extroverted and socially confident, and "天花板" (ceiling) means the highest level or ultimate example. Together it means the most socially adept person possible.

³ **Hunan cuisine (湘菜)** - One of the Eight Great Traditions of Chinese cuisine, originating from Hunan province, known for its spicy and flavorful dishes using chili peppers, garlic, and shallots.

⁴ **Advancing by retreating (以退為進)** - A Chinese idiom and strategic concept meaning to make progress by appearing to withdraw; using a tactical retreat to gain advantage; making it seem like you're backing down when you're actually trying to achieve your goal through indirect means.